



Te Tāhuhu o
te Mātauranga
Ministry of Education

Education Indicator

STUDENT ENGAGEMENT / PARTICIPATION

Students attending school regularly - Term 1 2026

Nationally, 68.8% of students met the criteria for regular attendance (present more than 90% of the term). This is an increase of 2.9 percentage points from Term 1 2025.

Indicator description

Regular attendance measures the percentage of students who have attended more than 90% of the term, where time is measured in half-days.¹

Other attendance categories are:

- irregular absence where students attended more than 80% and up to 90% of the term
- moderate absence where students attended more than 70% and up to 80% of the term
- chronic absence where students attended 70% or less of the term.

Why regular attendance is important

Attendance is linked to both student attainment and wellbeing. Research² shows that each additional half-day of absence from school and kura is associated with a consistent reduction in the number of NCEA credits students subsequently attain – whether this is a student moving from 100% to 99% attendance or moving from 71% to 70% attendance. Students who are absent 5-10% of the time (which is still considered “regular” attendance) still obtain fewer NCEA credits than those with higher attendance rates.

Student wellbeing is a key priority for the education system. Ministry of Education insight studies³ show that attending school and kura regularly is, on average, associated with more positive wellbeing outcomes. Ministry analysis found that 15-year-old students who reported skipping a greater number of school days in the previous fortnight reported worse outcomes on average for a number of wellbeing measures: schoolwork-related anxiety, sense of belonging, exposure to bullying, motivation and experiences of teacher unfairness.

¹ A half-day of attendance is a minimum of two hours present. Two half-days, or a minimum four hours, equates to a count of one day present.

² [He Whakaaro: What is the relationship between attendance and attainment?](#)

³ [He Whakaaro: School attendance and student wellbeing](#)

Short-term illness and unjustified reasons for absence

Short-term illness/medical absences continued to be the main driver of non-attendance, accounting for 4.7% of absent time in Term 1 2026. Unjustified absences declined to 3.5% of total term time in Term 1 2026, from 4.0% in Term 1 2025. Absence recorded as truancy or unknown reason accounted for 1.6% of term time.

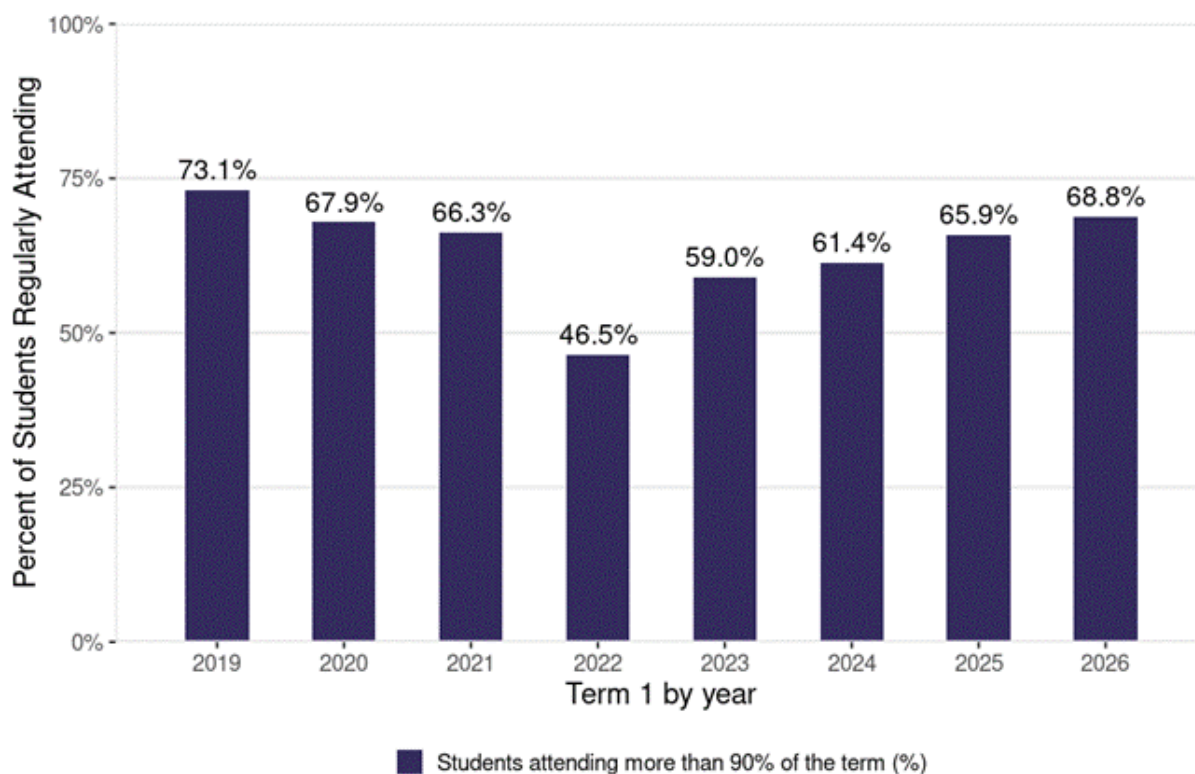
How are we going?

In Term 1 2026, 68.8% of students met the criteria for regular attendance. This is an increase of 2.9 percentage points from Term 1 2025 (65.9%). The gap to the government target of 80% of students regularly attending is 11.2 percentage points.

Table 1: Attendance rates compared across Term 1 2026 and Term 1 2025

Attendance categories	Percentage attendance	Term 1 2026	Term 1 2025
Regular attendance	more than 90% of the term	68.8% ▲	65.9%
Irregular absence	more than 80% and up to 90% of the term	18.7% ▼	20.6%
Moderate absence	more than 70% and up to 80% of the term	6.5% ▼	7.1%
Chronic absence	70% or less of the term	6.1% ▼	6.5%

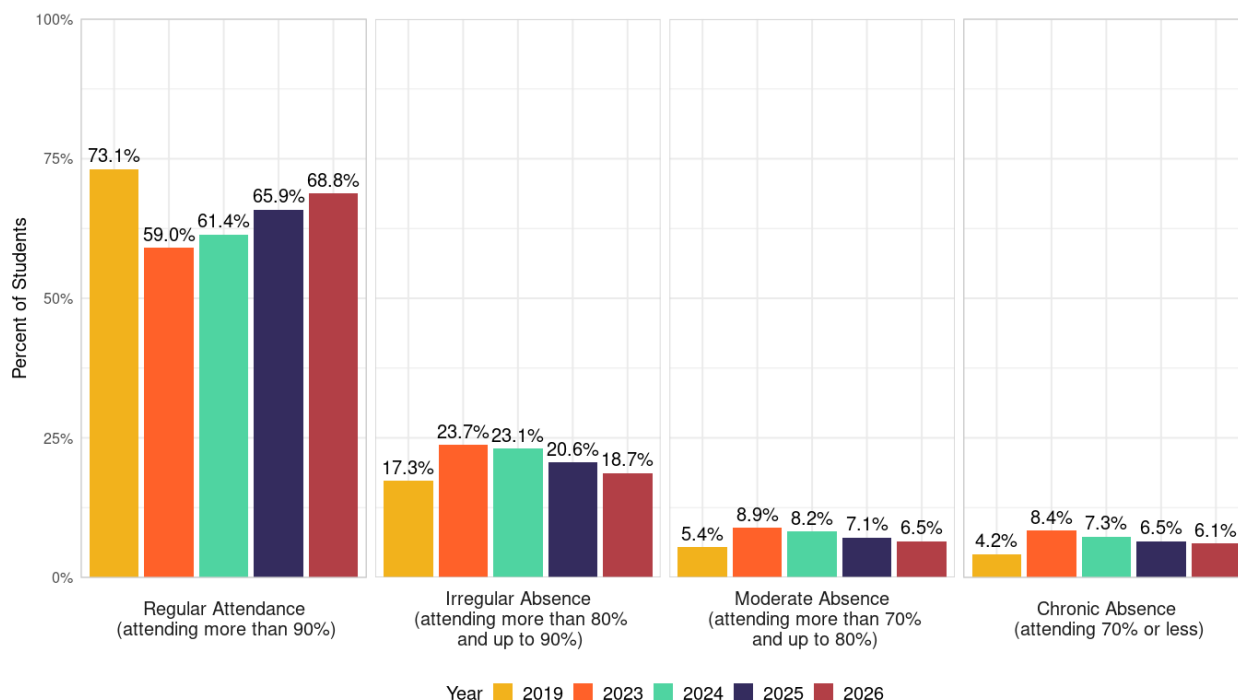
Figure 1: The percent of students regularly attending school and kura in Term 1 2019-2026



Compared to Term 1 2025, the rates for **irregular absence**, **moderate absence** and **chronic absence** decreased in Term 1 2026.

Since Term 1 2025, irregular absence decreased by 1.9 percentage points, moderate absence decreased by 0.6 percentage points and chronic absence decreased by 0.4 percentage points, contributing to an overall increase in the percentage of students attending school regularly in Term 1 2026.

Figure 2: Attendance rates in Term 1 compared across 2019, 2023, 2024, 2025 and 2026 – percent of students



Attendance by region

Compared to Term 1 2025, regular attendance was up across all education regions.

Tāmaki Herenga Manawa | Central and East Auckland region had the highest percentage of students attending regularly in Term 1 2026 (75.6%) followed by Tāmaki Herenga Tāngata | North and West Auckland region (73.5%).

Tāmaki Herenga Waka | South and South-West Auckland region had the largest increase in regular attendance compared to Term 1 2025 (4.1 percentage points). Regular attendance for Taranaki, Whanganui, Manawatū increased by 3.9 percentage points.

Tai Tokerau region had the lowest percentage of students attending regularly in Term 1 2026 (55.1%).

Table 2: Percentage of students regularly attending by education region for Term 1 2026 and Term 1 2025

Education region	Term 1 2025 (%)	Term 1 2026 (%)	Term 1 2026 – Term 1 2025 (percentage point difference)
Tai Tokerau	54.1	55.1	1.0
Auckland	67.3	70.9	3.6
• Tāmaki Herenga Tāngata North and West Auckland	70.0	73.5	3.5
• Tāmaki Herenga Manawa Central and East Auckland	72.3	75.6	3.3
• Tāmaki Herenga Waka South and South-West Auckland	57.9	62.0	4.1
Waikato	62.7	65.7	3.0
Bay of Plenty, Waiariki	61.9	65.4	3.5
Hawke's Bay, Tairāwhiti	61.1	63.7	2.6
Taranaki, Whanganui, Manawatū	64.7	68.6	3.9
Wellington	66.6	68.0	1.4
Nelson, Marlborough, West Coast	67.7	70.0	2.3
Canterbury and Chatham Islands	69.5	72.0	2.5
Otago, Southland	70.3	72.7	2.4

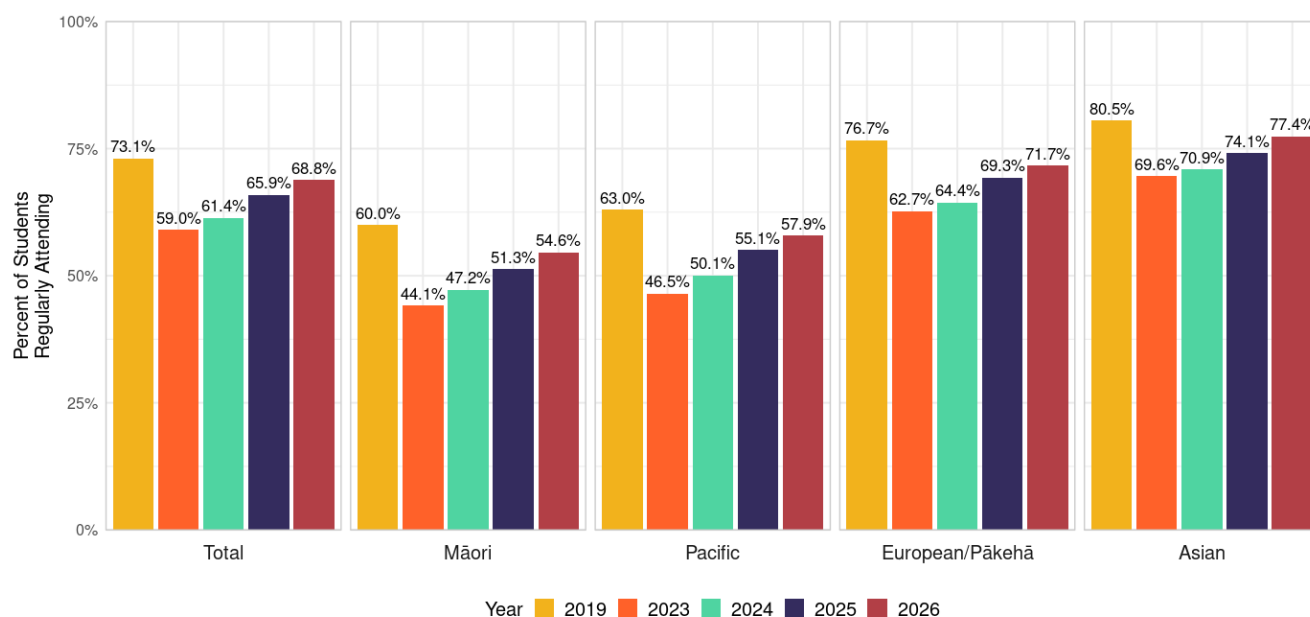
Attendance rates by ethnicity

In Term 1 2026, regular attendance was 54.6% for ākonga Māori, 57.9% for Pacific students, 77.4% for Asian students, and 71.7% for European/Pākehā students.

Regular attendance for Pacific students increased by 2.8 percentage points compared to Term 1 2025. The regular attendance rate for European/Pākehā students increased by 2.4 percentage points.

Ākonga Māori and Asian students had the highest increase in regular attendance rates of 3.3 percentage points each, compared to Term 1 2025.

Figure 3: Regular attendance has increased for students of all ethnicities in Term 1 2026 compared to Term 1 2025



Attendance for ākonga Māori

In Term 1 2026, attendance was reported for 202,032 ākonga Māori. Of these ākonga, 6.4% (12,841) were in kura/schools where teaching and learning is predominantly in te reo Māori.⁴

In Term 1 2026, the regular attendance rate for all ākonga Māori increased by 3.3 percentage points, from 51.3% in Term 1 2025 to 54.6% in Term 1 2026. The regular attendance rate for ākonga Māori predominantly learning in te reo Māori increased by 3.3 percentage points, from 43.4% in Term 1 2025 to 46.7% in Term 1 2026.

In Term 1 2026, the gap in regular attendance rates between all ākonga Māori and those predominantly learning in te reo Māori was 7.9 percentage points – unchanged from Term 1 2025.

Figure 4: Regular attendance for ākonga Māori predominantly learning in te reo Māori, and all ākonga Māori in Term 1 from 2019-2026 – Percent of students



⁴ This is a subset of all ākonga Māori predominantly learning in te reo Māori, based on ākonga Māori attending kura/schools where all students are predominantly learning in te reo Māori (more than 50% of the time). It does not include ākonga Māori predominantly learning in te reo Māori who are attending schools where the medium of education across the school is predominantly English.

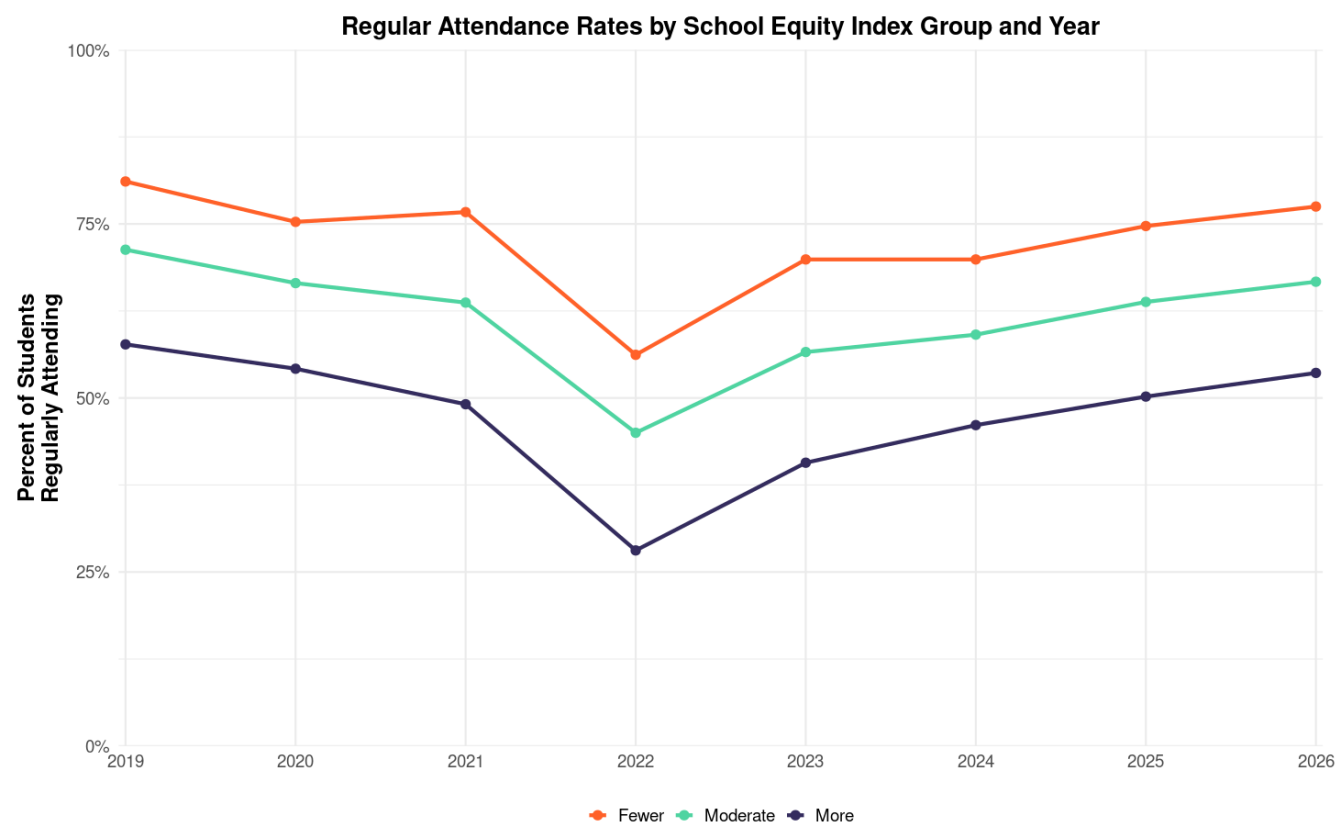
Attendance by school equity index groups and bands

Regular attendance by school equity index groups shows that regular attendance rates are higher for schools with students who face fewer socioeconomic barriers to achievement. Attendance rates for all equity index groups increased in Term 1 from 2025 to 2026.⁵

In Term 1 2026, regular attendance rates for schools with students facing more socioeconomic barriers to achievement increased by 3.4 percentage points from Term 1 2025 to 53.8%.

The regular attendance rates increased by 2.9 percentage points from Term 1 2025 for students facing moderate and fewer socioeconomic barriers. The regular attendance rate for schools with students facing moderate socioeconomic barriers rose to 67.3%, while those with fewer socioeconomic barriers increased to 78.0%.

Figure 5: Regular attendance rates for all school equity index groups increased from Term 1 2025 to Term 1 2026



⁵ While the equity index has been in use only since 2023, here Equity Index bands and groups are used from 2019 onwards. This is done using 2023 Equity index numbers in order to provide a time series for socioeconomic analysis, as 2023 EQI numbers provide a reasonable estimation of the socioeconomic circumstances of a school's learners back to 2019.

There is a great deal of school-to-school variation within the equity index groups and bands. The jitter plot in Figure 6 shows the distribution of regular attendance rates in Term 1 2026 grouped by their Equity Index bands.

In Term 1 of 2026, schools with students experiencing the fewest socioeconomic barriers had a regular attendance rate of 80.1%, compared with just 48.8% for schools where students faced the most socioeconomic barriers.

Figure 6: The average regular attendance rates are lower for students in schools with higher socioeconomic barriers to achievement

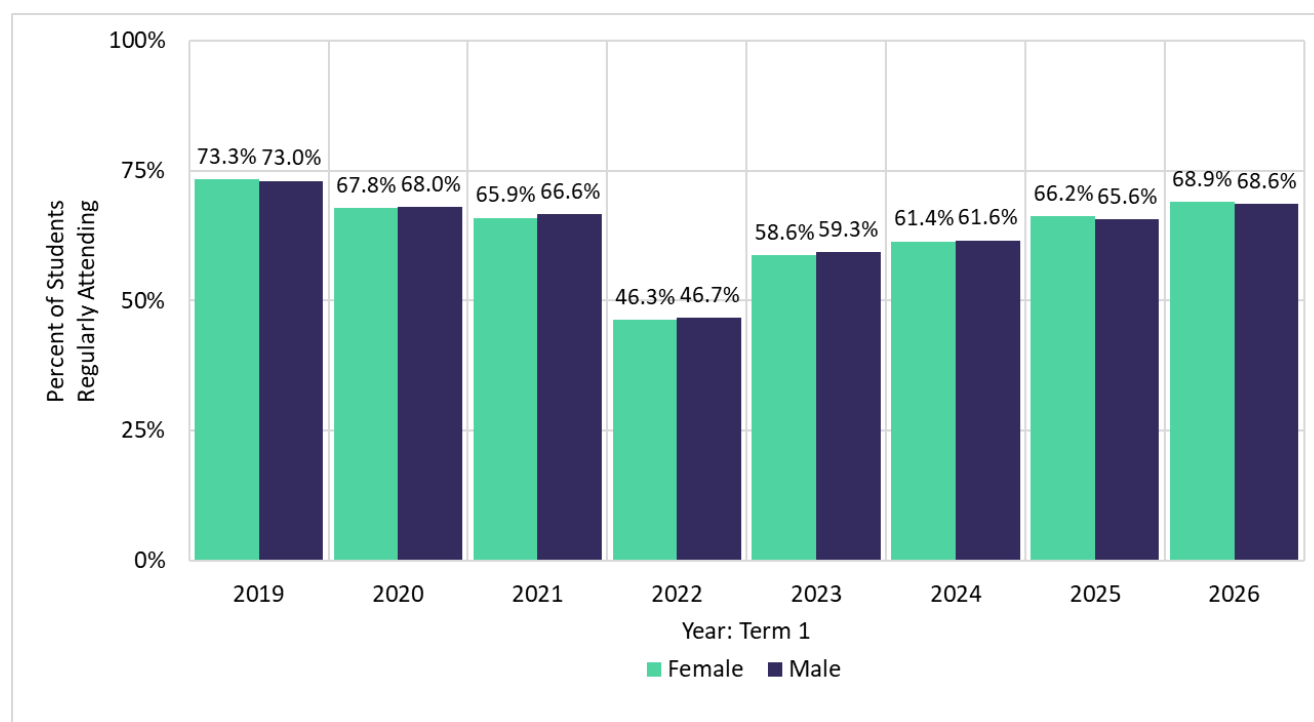


The solid line is the average percentage of students attending regularly for each band. Each coloured dot denotes an individual school within each band. The variation in attendance rates is greater in bands where students have more socioeconomic barriers to achievement. Very high and very low regular attendance rates are predominantly for small schools (25 students or fewer).

Attendance by gender ⁶

In Term 1 2026, the regular attendance rates for both male and female students increased. Compared with Term 1 2025, the percentage of female students regularly attending school increased by 2.7 percentage points to 68.9% while the percentage of male students regularly attending school increased by 3.0 percentage points, to 68.6% in Term 1 2026.

Figure 7: Regular attendance by gender in Term 1 from 2019-2026 – Percent of students



⁶ From 2023, the Ministry has begun to allow for gender values other than male and female. At present not all Student Management Systems (SMS) can record this information. It will also take time to build an accurate picture of the population of students recording a non-binary gender because students' details are generally only updated when they first enrol at school or when they change schools.

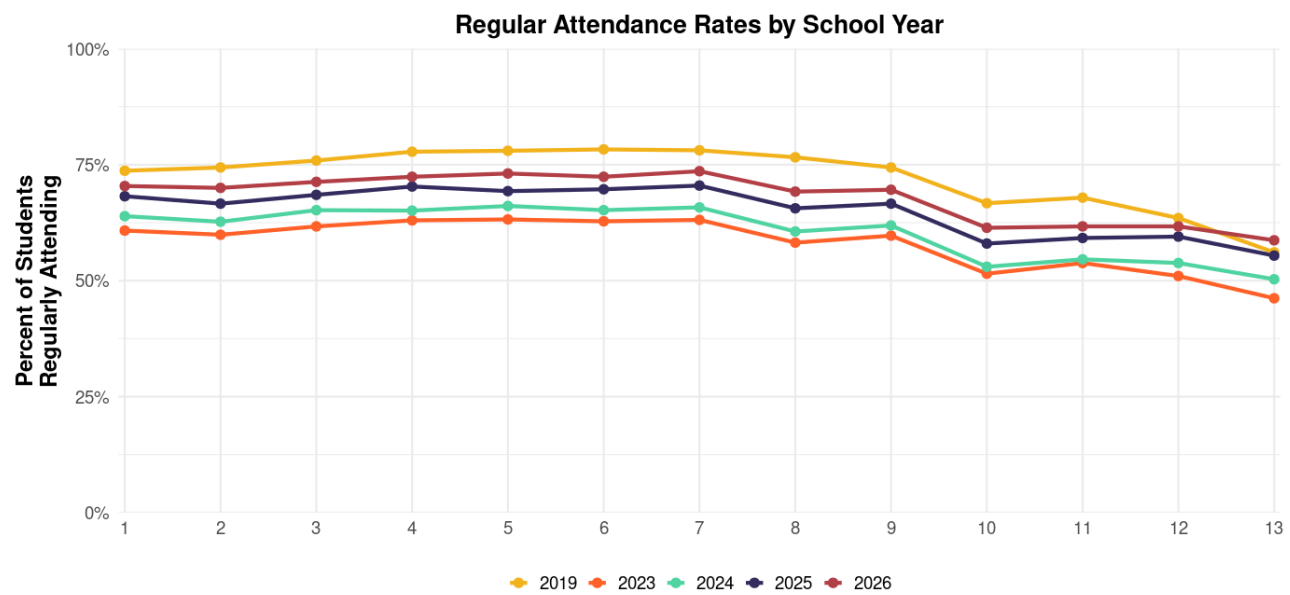
Attendance by year level

In Term 1 2026, regular attendance rates across all year levels increased compared to Term 1 2025.

Year 5 students had the largest increase in regular attendance, from 69.7% in Term 1 2025 to 73.5% in Term 1 2026, an increase of 3.8 percentage points.

Overall, compared to Term 1 2025, the regular attendance rate for primary students (Year 1-8) increased by 3.0 percentage points to 72.0%, while the overall rate for secondary students (Year 9-13) increased by 2.9 percentage points to 63.7%.

Figure 8: Regular attendance increased across all year levels in Term 1 2026 compared to Term 1 2025



About the data

In Term 1 2026, all schools and kura (100% response rate) provided attendance data.

Where to find out more

For information on the Government's strategy to lift school attendance:

- [Increasing school attendance - Ministry of Education](#)

To obtain more information about student attendance, consider publications:

- [Attendance | Education Counts](#)
- [Daily attendance | Education Counts](#)
- [He Whakaaro: School attendance and student wellbeing](#)
- [He Whakaaro: What is the relationship between attendance and attainment?](#)

To obtain information about other forms of student engagement, consider indicators:

- [Stand-downs, suspensions, exclusions and expulsions from school](#)
- [Early leaving exemptions](#)
- [Transient students](#)
- [School leaver's attainment](#)

To obtain information about the school equity index:

- [The Equity Index](#)
- [School Equity Index Bands and Groups](#)